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★★★★ \$5.00

DIJA Closed (43297.03)

NASDAQ Closed (20031.13)

STOXX 600 Closed (503.81)

10-YR. TREAS. Closed (4.584%)

OIL Closed (\$70.10)

GOLD Closed (\$2620.00)

EURO \$1.0411

YEN 157.20

What's News

Business & Finance

◆ **Many companies** that denounced the 2021 invasion of the U.S. Capitol and pledged to withhold support from those who disputed the 2020 election results are now lining up to fund Trump's inauguration. **A1**

◆ **Trump's plan** to impose new import tariffs on Mexican-built vehicles threatens to exacerbate the difficulty U.S. buyers already face in finding an affordable car. **A1**

◆ **U.S. stocks rose** in a shortened pre-Christmas session on Tuesday, with the S&P 500, Nasdaq and Dow gaining 1.1%, 1.3% and 0.9%, respectively. U.S. markets were closed Wednesday for the holiday. **B10**

◆ **Jump Trading unit** Tai Mo Shan agreed to pay \$123 million to settle an investigation stemming from its dealings with disgraced crypto tycoon Do Kwon. **B1**

◆ **Trade groups** representing the country's biggest banks sued the Fed, accusing it of using an opaque process to test banks' resiliency during annual stress tests. **B3**

◆ **Thai oil-and-gas giant** PTT Exploration & Production plans to invest \$5.3 billion to boost key assets and speed up its overseas development projects in 2025. **B3**

◆ **American Airlines** avoided a Christmas Eve meltdown when it resumed flights after a vendor technology issue briefly halted the carrier's operations. **B2**

◆ **Swisscom said** authorities in Italy approved its acquisition of Vodafone Italia, a deal that is expected to be completed in the first quarter of 2025. **B4**

World-Wide

◆ **At least 38 people** were killed when a passenger jet headed for Russia crashed in Kazakhstan in an incident that Ukraine officials and aviation experts said was likely caused by Russian anti-aircraft fire. **A1**

◆ **Israel and Hamas** accused each other of complicating cease-fire efforts as the two sides inch closer to an agreement that could wind down the war in Gaza. **A6**

◆ **Pope Francis used** his traditional Christmas message to urge people of all nations to help bring about peace in the world by becoming "pilgrims of hope." **A6**

◆ **A deadly two-plane** collision in Tokyo early this year happened because a pilot mistakenly believed he had been given permission to enter the runway for takeoff, the Japanese government's crash investigation found. **A5**

◆ **More than 400,000** students without permanent legal status enrolled in American colleges await what the president-elect has pledged to be the largest deportation program in U.S. history. **A3**

◆ **Panama stepped up** efforts to close jungle trails used by smugglers to direct migrants on their way to the U.S. from South America via the treacherous Darién Gap. **A7**

◆ **Biden signed** legislation that designates the bald eagle as the country's national bird, a status long held in the popular imagination but not made official until Tuesday. **A4**

◆ **Died: Richard Perry**, 82, record producer. **A4** ... **Desi Bouterse**, 79, former Suriname strongman leader. **A6**

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Kyiv Shows Colors of Christmas Amid New Attack



THOMAS PETER/REUTERS

PAGEANTRY: Carolers in traditional Ukrainian garb celebrated Christmas outside St. Michael's Golden-Domed Monastery in Kyiv, even as Russia launched a massive missile and drone barrage targeting the country's energy infrastructure. **A6**

Airliner Crashes, 38 Dead; Shootdown by Russia Eyed

Plane falls from the sky in Kazakhstan; experts see signs of anti-aircraft strike

By MATTHEW LUXMOORE AND BENJAMIN KATZ

At least 38 people were killed when a passenger jet headed for Russia crashed in Kazakhstan in an incident that Ukraine officials and aviation experts said was likely caused by Russian anti-aircraft fire.

The Azerbaijan Airlines plane was flying from Baku in Azerbaijan to Grozny in Russia and diverted its course over an area where Moscow's air defenses have battled Ukrainian drones in recent weeks. The flight—carrying 62 passengers and five crew members—crashed near the city of Aktau in western Kazakhstan after turning around and flying east over the Caspian Sea. As many as 29 passengers survived.

Citing assessments of footage of the crash, the damage to the aircraft, and recent military activity, aviation-security firm, Osprey Flight Solutions, said in an alert to airlines that the flight “was likely shot down by a Russian military air-defense system.”



AZAMAT SAKSIBAYEV/REUTERS

The Azerbaijan Airlines jet crashed near Aktau, Kazakhstan.

“Video of the wreckage and the circumstances around the airspace security environment in southwest Russia indicates the possibility the aircraft was hit by some form of anti-aircraft fire,” Matt Borie, chief intelligence officer at Osprey, said in an interview.

A Ukrainian national-security official, Andrii Kovalenko, said in an X post that the plane “was shot down by a Russian air-defense system,” citing visible damage to the plane. “Russia should have closed

the airspace over Grozny but failed to do so,” Kovalenko said. “The plane was damaged by the Russians and was sent to Kazakhstan instead of being urgently landed in Grozny to save lives.”

Russian officials couldn't be reached for comment about the Osprey and Ukraine assessments.

Azerbaijan and Kazakhstan said they were cooperating on an investigation and cited different potential reasons for the crash.

Azerbaijan Airlines said the Embraer 190 passenger jet may have collided with a flock of birds. Azerbaijan's president said that he was told the plane had been diverted due to poor weather conditions. He said an investigation into the incident was ongoing. Officials said the aircraft's black box was recovered.

Footage posted from near the scene on Wednesday morning showed the aircraft in flames after it made an emergency landing in a field.

Twenty-five minutes before the plane was scheduled to land in Grozny, its crew alerted air-traffic controllers at Aktau airport that they needed to make an emergency landing there, the ministry said.

Half an hour later, shortly before noon local time, the plane crashed in a field about 2 miles from Aktau airport. Flight-tracking service Flightradar24 said heavy GPS spoofing in the area, which tampers with signals so a plane's position can't be tracked, could have complicated any diversion.

Some aviation experts said that perforations in the plane's tail section, visible in footage of the crash site posted by Kazakhstan's Emergency Ministry, suggested the plane was hit by a missile. *Please turn to page A5*

Trump Inaugural Donors Look Past Jan. 6

Four years ago, dozens of companies denounced the invasion of the U.S. Capitol and pledged to withhold support from those who disputed the

By Rebecca Ballhaus, Dana Mattioli, Shalini Ramachandran and Maggie Severns

2020 election results. Now, many of those companies are lining up to fund Donald Trump's inauguration.

The Wall Street Journal has identified at least 11 companies and trade associations that are backing the inauguration, which is on track to bring in a record fundraising haul, after earlier pledging to suspend or reconsider political-action committee donations after Jan. 6, 2021.

Ford, Intuit, Toyota and the Pharmaceutical Research and Manufacturers of America are each giving \$1 million. Other major donors that made Jan. 6-related pledges include Goldman Sachs, General Motors, Bank of America, AT&T and Stanley Black & Decker.

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Affordable Cars Face Big Hit On Tariffs

By SEAN MCLAIN

Finding an affordable car in the U.S. has already become a challenge for many budget-constrained Americans. New import tariffs on Mexican-built vehicles threaten to make the problem worse.

Today, nearly one-third of all vehicles priced below \$30,000 and sold in the U.S. are built in Mexico, including the Nissan Sentra, Ford Maverick and other popular nameplates, according to an analysis by car-shopping website Edmunds. A decade ago, Mexico was responsible for one-fifth of the affordable cars sold in the U.S., the firm's

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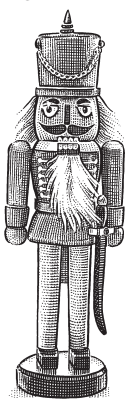
◆ **Telecom lawyer's climb** to the top of FCC..... **A4**

A Ballet's Greatest Gift: Job Security

◆ **‘The Nutcracker’** is a gig dancers can't quit

By JACOB PASSY

Looking for a seasonal gig that could last for a half-century or more? Consider dancing in “The Nutcracker.”



in 36 of those years.

When Boal became artistic director of Seattle's Pacific Northwest Ballet in 2005, his former boss challenged him to

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INSIDE



JEFFREY DEAN/BLOOMBERG NEWS

BUSINESS & FINANCE

Succession plan is brewing with chair's wife set to inherit Boston Beer stake. **B1**



SPORTS

Lindsey Vonn got a knee replacement. Can she get to the 2026 Olympics? **A12**

Rebel Leaders Control Syria. What Happens Now?

Islamist guerrilla who promised moderation asks for patience

By JARED MALSIN

DAMASCUS, Syria—Victorious Islamist rebel leader Ahmed al-Sharaa spends his days conferring with advisers and meeting a stream of visitors—U.S. diplomats and leaders from Turkey, Jordan, Qatar and Syria's religious sects.

They all want to know the same thing: How does Sharaa plan to govern the war-battered nation of 23 million people?

Sharaa, a guerrilla fighter who led the campaign that toppled the regime of Bashar al-Assad, is seeking an answer. So far, the

U.S.-designated terrorist has shed the nom de guerre Abu Mohammed al-Jawlani, which drew the world's attention, and swapped combat fatigues for a suit.

Sharaa fought with al Qaeda in Iraq as an anti-U.S. jihadist and, in recent years, has sought to recast himself as a more moderate figure, promoting a pragmatic brand of Islamist politics. He now counsels patience.

“People have big ambitions, but today we must think realistically,” he told reporters after the rebels' swift victory. “Syria has many problems, and they won't be solved

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Risky Borrowers' Credit Scores Slump

By DAVID UBERTI AND KATHERINE HAMILTON

Adrianna Boshears's dream of homeownership seemed within reach for the first time in 2021. She and her husband, Jeffrey, were finally saving money because of pandemic stimulus checks and a larger-than-usual tax refund. A real-estate agent suggested

they work to boost their low credit scores before applying for a mortgage.

The couple's scores rose after Adrianna opened her first credit card, and then vaulted into the 700s after the couple added four others. But as their savings dwindled, the 41-year-old mom started pulling out the plastic to pay for groceries and utilities. By Oc-

tober, the kitchen cabinets in her Fresno, Calif., apartment were bare. All five cards were maxed out.

Their balances now exceed \$10,000. Adrianna's credit score has fallen to 569. There are no more dreams of buying a house.

“I make more money than I did back then, and I'm struggling,” she says. *Please turn to page A2*